WEEK 10 · LECTURE L2 · UNIT IV

Hybrid and Flexible Work

What the evidence supports, the equity trap of two-tier hybrid, and flexibility beyond the desk.

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AFTER THIS LECTURE YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO

What this lecture prepares you for

- Apply Gratton's two axes and four perspectives to hybrid design.
- Explain the equity trap of two-tier hybrid work in organizations with large frontlines.
- Distinguish temporal, spatial and contractual flexibility.
- Apply Bloom et al., boundary theory, organizational justice and Susskind to flexible work.

COURSE OUTCOMES

CLO 1 and CLO 5 (hybrid and flexible work).

GRATTON (2021)

Two axes and four perspectives

Element	The question
Axis: place	From the office to anywhere
Axis: time	From fixed hours to any time (asynchronous)
Perspective: jobs and tasks	Which tasks need energy, focus, coordination or cooperation?
Perspective: employee preferences	What do people need and want?
Perspective: projects and workflows	Must the workflow be redesigned?
Perspective: inclusion and fairness	Who is eligible, and who is structurally excluded?

EXAM LENS

Designs usually fail on the fourth perspective, inclusion and fairness.

THE EQUITY TRAP

Who can work hybrid?

Desk-based staff

In many Indian organizations a minority of staff work in corporate roles with laptops; hybrid by place reaches them.

Everyone else

Store, factory, warehouse and delivery staff work fixed shifts, often with only a phone.

The trap

Hybrid offered only to desk staff creates two tiers: flexibility for some, fixed shifts for the rest.

FLEXIBILITY BEYOND THE DESK

Three kinds of flexibility

Kind	Examples	Possible for frontline staff?
Temporal	Flextime, compressed weeks, shift swaps	Yes: app-based shift swaps and advance rosters
Spatial	Remote work, co-working	Rarely: the work is on site
Contractual	Part-time, job sharing, phased retirement	Yes, with equal benefits pro rata

EXAM LENS

Design rule: if place cannot flex, give people control over time.

What the experiments show

THE CORE IDEA

Bloom et al.'s 2015 randomized trial at a Chinese travel firm found that full home working raised call-center performance by 13%.

HOW IT WORKS

A 2024 trial at the same firm found two home days a week cut quit rates by a third, with no harm to performance or promotion.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Results come from one firm and specific jobs; fully remote work has weaker evidence for collaboration and innovation.

IN PRACTICE

Hybrid can be a low-cost retention tool for desk staff, but it does nothing for staff whose work is on site.

EXAM LENS

Randomized evidence is the strongest you can cite; state its single-firm limitation.

THEORY IN DEPTH · ASHFORTH, KREINER AND FUGATE (2000)

People manage boundaries between work and home

THE CORE IDEA

Boundary theory: people segment or integrate their roles, and transitions between roles cost effort.

HOW IT WORKS

Hybrid blurs boundaries; some people thrive on integration, others need segmentation.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Individual preferences vary widely, so one policy rarely suits all.

IN PRACTICE

Let teams agree norms on availability rather than imposing one rule for everyone.

EXAM LENS

Use boundary theory to explain why the same hybrid policy helps some employees and harms others.

THEORY IN DEPTH · GREENBERG (1987); COLQUITT (2001)

Eligibility decisions are judged on justice

THE CORE IDEA

Organizational justice has four forms: distributive, procedural, interpersonal and informational.

HOW IT WORKS

People accept unequal outcomes more readily when the process is fair and explained.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Justice perceptions differ across cultures and status groups.

IN PRACTICE

If frontline staff cannot have hybrid work, explain why, and offer a fair equivalent such as control over shifts.

EXAM LENS

Colquitt's four dimensions give a precise structure for evaluating any flexibility policy.

THEORY IN DEPTH · SUSSKIND (2020)

Machines take tasks, then more tasks

THE CORE IDEA

Task encroachment: technology takes over task after task, gradually shrinking the demand for human work.

HOW IT WORKS

Some workers are complemented today, but the set of tasks left for people keeps narrowing.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Critics argue new tasks keep appearing, as in past waves of technology (see Acemoglu and Restrepo, L3).

IN PRACTICE

Roles with high routine content, such as warehouse operation, will see their task mix change first.

EXAM LENS

Present Susskind as one side of a debate, with Acemoglu and Restrepo's reinstatement effect as the counterpoint.

PRACTICE FOR THE END-TERM EXAMINATION

Questions to rehearse

"Hybrid work is a privilege of the desk-based minority." Critically evaluate using Gratton (2021), organizational justice and the evidence from Bloom et al. **20 marks**

A strong answer: applies all four perspectives; uses experimental evidence with limits; Colquitt's dimensions; proposes temporal and contractual flexibility for frontline staff.

Discuss the implications of boundary theory and task encroachment for HR policy on flexible work. **20 marks**

A strong answer: explains segmentation and integration; Susskind versus reinstatement; links to job design and reskilling.

Distinguish temporal, spatial and contractual flexibility with examples. **10 marks**

A strong answer: gives correct, distinct examples for each.

CARRY THESE INTO THE EXAMINATION

Three things to remember

1. **Design hybrid through all four perspectives, especially fairness**
2. **Hybrid by place reaches only desk-based staff**
3. **Where place cannot flex, give people control over time**

SET READINGS · FROM THE LESSON PLAN

Read for this lecture

- Gratton, L. (2021). How to do hybrid right. *Harvard Business Review, 99*(3).
- Susskind, D. (2020). *A World Without Work*, selected chapter.

COMPANION

Each set reading is explained in the matching Unit Reader on rksingh.tech/materials.

THEORY SOURCES · FOR REFERENCE

Sources for this lecture

Works named on the slides of this lecture. They are background sources, not set readings.

Ashforth, B. E., Kreiner, G. E., & Fugate, M. (2000). All in a day's work: Boundaries and micro role transitions. *The Academy of Management Review, 25*(3), 472–491. https://doi.org/10.2307/259305

Bloom, N., Han, R., & Liang, J. (2024). Hybrid working from home improves retention without damaging performance. *Nature, 630*(8018), 920–925. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41586-024-07500-2

Bloom, N., Liang, J., Roberts, J., & Ying, Z. J. (2015). Does working from home work? Evidence from a Chinese experiment. *The Quarterly Journal of Economics, 130*(1), 165–218. https://doi.org/10.1093/qje/qju032

Colquitt, J. A. (2001). On the dimensionality of organizational justice: A construct validation of a measure. *Journal of Applied Psychology, 86*(3), 386–400. https://doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.86.3.386

Gratton, L. (2021). How to do hybrid right. *Harvard Business Review, 99*(3).

Greenberg, J. (1987). A taxonomy of organizational justice theories. *The Academy of Management Review, 12*(1), 9–22. https://doi.org/10.2307/257990

Susskind, D. (2020). *A world without work: Technology, automation, and how we should respond*. Allen Lane.